

Chapter 11 - Forbidden Book

Ning Fuyi seemed frozen in place, staring at the scene before her that filled her with horror. Those bubbles kept emerging endlessly, almost flooding the entire Sacred Heavenly Sundial. Some even floated in the air, surging toward the crowd, where some younger disciples reached out their hands to curiously pop them.

In her previous life, Ning Fuyi had lived for so many years and experienced all kinds of terrifying things, yet she had never seen such a frightening scene. She was so horrified that her face darkened and she let out some unspeakable profanity.

Setting aside the fact that she had actually broken through, just thinking about how she, the great first Demon King of the Four Seas and Eight Wastelands¹, who could summon thunder from above and call forth evil spirits from below, revered by millions of demonic cultivators - if they knew she had now summoned such a pile of ridiculous things, how could she maintain her authority in the demon realm in the future?

Embarrassing, too embarrassing.

"This..." The elders were all tongue-tied, thrown into disarray for a moment. Finally, Rong Jin reacted first, striding into that pile of bubbles and waving his hand to sweep them away.

"Ning Fuyi, Mortal Realm²!" His words carried undisguised joy.

"As for the spell system..." He stared at those bubbles for a long time, momentarily speechless.

Generally speaking, the five major spell systems of Wind, Thunder, Water, Fire, and Wood³ were easy to distinguish. Although each person manifested differently, and sometimes in outrageous ways, there was always a way to categorize them. But these gurgling pink bubbles were too... suggestive...

Elder Pingyao was still the first to regain her composure. She waved her hand lightly, and all the bubbles in the hall disappeared. Then she walked to the sundial with her hands behind her back, stroking her chin in thought for a moment.

"Let's consider it Water system for now." She said with difficulty, then looked at the motionless Ning Fuyi. "At least you've broken through to Mortal Realm. That's progress."

"Don't waste time. Next person." She quickly looked away, returning to her stern demeanor.

Under Elder Pingyao's efforts, order gradually returned to the hall, but many disciples were still immersed in the scene they had just witnessed, whispering among themselves with their heads down.

"Ning Fuyi actually broke through to Mortal Realm. I thought she'd be stuck at Initial Realm⁴ for life," someone secretly said.

"Yeah, truly incredible. Could it be that the former sect master's passing was such a blow to her that it motivated her to work harder?"

"Who knows? But what spell system was that exactly? It didn't look like Water system magic to me," another person said, craning their neck.

Ning Fuyi returned to her seat with stiff legs, ignoring these whispers. She tried hard to forget about those bubbles and instead fell into confusion. She knew that in her previous life, she was still only at Initial Realm even when she turned demonic. At that time, she had desperately tried to cultivate but achieved nothing. How had she suddenly broken through after being reborn?

Truly baffling.

However, seeing Li Chao'an's furious expression beside her, she still felt some satisfaction. If she could make someone she disliked angry, then this cultivation advancement was worth it.

Although she was destined to turn demonic anyway, which was somewhat regrettable.

"Yiyi, yiyi!" Liu Wenzhu's shaking interrupted her thoughts. The girl seemed even more joyful than she was, so happy that her usually meticulous hair was flying about. "You broke through to Mortal Realm! We might be able to go to Zhaoyao Mountain⁵ together!"

Breaking through to Mortal Realm was nothing special. Even with this breakthrough, in this cultivation world full of capable people, she was still just a drop in the ocean, and no one would look up to her. For her, there was no difference between this and Initial Realm.

But seeing Liu Wenzhu's bright, sparkling eyes, Ning Fuyi's disappointing words stopped at the tip of her tongue and were swallowed back down.

"Yes, maybe," Ning Fuyi smiled.

What followed was much the same as she remembered from her previous life. Liu Wenzhu had already broken through to Rising Realm⁶, with Fire system magic. As soon as her blood dropped, a majestic fire dragon emerged from the mirror, roaring once and drawing gasps of amazement.

Afterward, Liu Wenzhu walked down with a face red as a tomato, moving with delicate steps like a willow swaying in the wind.

The only difference was that near the end, Qiu Yi walked in. According to Elder Pingyao, she had joined Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate as Chu Qingqiu's disciple and would cultivate with them from now on.

As Chu Qingqiu's only disciple, she didn't bring shame to her master either. She had the same Wind system as Chu Qingqiu and already possessed Clear Realm⁷ cultivation, the same as Li Chao'an.

When the evening breeze was blowing and the setting sun was like molten gold, the day's immortal instruction finally ended. The sect master and elders left first, and the disciples finally breathed a sigh of relief, noisily leaving Suspended Beam Garden⁸ in groups.

Ning Fuyi and Liu Wenzhu followed the crowd out the door. Rong Jin stood at the entrance waiting for them, placing a small box of rouge in each of their hands.

"Senior Brother Rong Jin, you've made new rouge again?" Liu Wenzhu smiled as she opened the lid, leaning forward to take a deep breath and closing her eyes in intoxication. "This time it's osmanthus-scented."

"Not only that - smell carefully, there's also jasmine fragrance," Rong Jin smiled warmly. "I also added dragon bone⁹ to Yiyi's, since she mentioned having trouble sleeping these past few days. I wonder if it will help."

"This color is beautiful too. Thank you, Senior Brother," Liu Wenzhu dabbed a little on her hand and smiled sweetly.

Ning Fuyi also lowered her head to smell it. The fresh floral fragrance made her somewhat dazed. These were the days she used to miss during her nightmares in the demon realm, waking up in the middle of the night with longing. Now that they were truly happening again, it still felt like a fleeting dream.

"Does Yiyi like it?" Rong Jin asked nervously, rubbing his hands.

"I like it," Ning Fuyi broke into a smile, carefully putting the rouge in her sleeve.

"I'm glad you like it. This time when I went to Zhaoyao Mountain, I heard that mortal girls also love to wear silk flowers in their hair. You two are usually too plain - when I learn the skill, I'll make more for you," Rong Jin said with a smile.

"I want purple ones," Liu Wenzhu lightly jumped up.

The three of them chatted and laughed as they walked down the mountain. Perhaps because her good friends were there, no one came to trouble Ning Fuyi this time. The weather was clear, and the distant mountains were dyed gold, spreading out in brilliant layers.

Ning Fuyi's heart also gradually brightened like those golden mountains.

As for Chu Qingqiu's words, she immediately threw them to the back of her mind and went happily to eat.

Since Elder Pingyao was watching her closely, she couldn't escape immortal instruction for the next few days. But no one supervised her morning cultivation, so Ning Fuyi still slept until she naturally woke up each day, getting up only after all the disciples in the dormitory had disappeared.

Since she temporarily couldn't practice demonic arts, she had stolen a forbidden book from the scripture library. The book recorded immortal cultivators throughout history who had fallen to demonization. Aside from those born as demons, most others fell due to incurable emotional wounds or great emotional upheaval that led to qi deviation¹⁰.

Only a very small portion was due to certain opportunities - being contaminated by demonic entities and coincidentally entering the demonic path. She memorized these opportunities in her heart, planning to try them one by one.

On this day, the hall was empty early on. She leisurely emerged from behind the screen, holding the forbidden book she had disguised as a story book using concealment magic, flipping through it with one hand while organizing her clothes with the other, dabbing some of the rouge Rong Jin had given her on her forehead.

She had loved wearing black in her previous life, so now she was also dressed in black robes, with only white patterns embroidered on the sleeves, removing some of the gloominess. Now paired with the red dot on her forehead, it inexplicably gave off a bewitching feeling.

Ning Fuyi nodded with satisfaction. Just as she was about to close the makeup box, she noticed a piece of osmanthus soap inside, so she poked it with her fingertip and picked it up with two fingers.

She remembered this soap was something Liu Wenzhu had stolen from the Liu family to give to her. It was said to contain immortal herbs, and after bathing with it, the fragrance would linger on one's body for a month.

Ning Fuyi sniffed herself again, wrinkling her nose in disgust. Then she took the soap and walked into the bathhouse.

When Ning Changfeng was alive, she was extremely considerate of the female disciples, so she had designed the bathhouse of Pearl Light Pavilion¹¹ with incredible ingenuity. There were thirty-six bath chambers in total, each able to accommodate several people bathing simultaneously. The pools were heated year-round, and the water was enchanted with immortal magic, appearing to be covered with rolling white mist.

The bathhouse was currently empty, so Ning Fuyi casually placed the book on the ground, undressed, and entered the water, contentedly narrowing her eyes.

However, just as she was enjoying herself, the air around her suddenly shifted. Ning Fuyi's heartstrings tightened, and she immediately opened her eyes.

At the same time, the sound of breaking through air rang out. A tall female figure shattered the void, appearing beside the bath pool with a strong wind. Ning Fuyi quickly raised her hands to block, and the water in the pool was swept up by the wind and splashed everywhere.

Most critically, the forbidden book that Ning Fuyi had originally placed at hand was blown away by the wind, flipping open to the middle page.

Unfortunately, that page depicted an illustration of someone pierced through the heart by ten swords, with the blood colored in cinnabar, a vivid red patch that was very conspicuous.

Ning Fuyi silently cursed her bad luck in her heart, unable to help but prop herself up and lean against the floor tiles defensively.

"So you're hiding here - I had quite a time looking for you!" The newcomer wore a light golden silk dress with an antique but obviously expensive jade hairpin in her hair. Her hair was meticulously arranged like Chu Qingqiu's, and she crossed her arms with an annoyed expression.

"Qiu Yi?" Ning Fuyi glanced at the book beside her with the corner of her eye, frowning. "What are you doing barging into the bathhouse?"

"Barging in? This is the women's bathhouse, and I'm also a woman - why can't I enter?" Qiu Yi disgustedly wiped the water from the bottom of her shoes. "I haven't even asked you yet - Master ordered you to come find her. Why didn't you go?"

So it was Chu Qingqiu who sent her. Ning Fuyi understood in her heart but pretended to be confused: "When was this order given? Why don't I know about it?"

"Stop playing dumb. I won't..." She was halfway through speaking when her gaze suddenly moved past Ning Fuyi to look at the ground behind her. "What is that?"

As soon as she finished speaking, she was about to wave her hand to summon the book on the ground. Ning Fuyi's heartbeat stopped for several beats, silently crying out in alarm, suddenly leaping up from the water.

As she rose, she wrapped herself in a layer of immortal power that quickly traveled along her body, then transformed into thin black clothing, barely covering the young woman's slender frame. However, her long legs were still faintly visible, and her wet long hair flowed down her shoulders like ink, covering her upper body.

She extended her dew-covered lotus-like arms, snatching the book back from mid-air.

Before Qiu Yi could make another move, a snow-white silk ribbon suddenly materialized from the void, whooshing over to cover Qiu Yi's eyes.

Like something alive, it quickly tied a knot behind her head, binding it so tightly that Qiu Yi's vision blurred and she nearly fell to her knees.

Author's Note: Qiu Yi: Master, you have love, you're noble, you're amazing!

Footnotes:

¹ Four Seas and Eight Wastelands (四海八荒) - A poetic expression meaning "everywhere in the world" or "all corners of the earth"

² Mortal Realm (凡境) - The second level in the cultivation hierarchy, above Initial Realm

³ The five spell systems: Wind (风), Thunder (雷), Water (水), Fire (火), Wood (木)

⁴ Initial Realm (初境) - The first and lowest level of cultivation

⁵ Zhaoyao Mountain (招摇山) - The location where the Grand Assembly is held

⁶ Rising Realm (起境) - The third level in the cultivation hierarchy

⁷ Clear Realm (明境) - The fourth level in the cultivation hierarchy

⁸ Suspended Beam Garden (悬梁苑) - A location within the sect where instruction takes place

⁹ Dragon bone (龙骨) - A traditional Chinese medicine ingredient, actually fossilized bones, used for calming and sleep

¹⁰ Qi deviation (走火入魔) - A dangerous condition in cultivation where one's spiritual energy goes out of control, often leading to demonization

¹¹ Pearl Light Pavilion (珠光阁) - The female disciples' dormitory building